

MOVING TO NORTHERN COLORADO

The Northern Colorado Relocation Guide

Most relocation guides are a brochure for the state. This one is about the twenty minutes between one town and the next — which is where the decision actually gets made.

Christine Gwinnup

Signature Property Collection · LPT Realty

36 towns, 6 counties, Denver north to the Wyoming line

START HERE

The only question that actually matters

If you are moving to Northern Colorado from somewhere else, the hard part is not finding a house. There are houses. The hard part is deciding which of roughly thirty towns you want to wake up in — from a thousand miles away, on the strength of one weekend visit, using a map that makes them all look about the same.

They are not the same. Fifteen minutes apart, two towns here can differ by a school district, a twenty-minute commute, a hundred thousand dollars of median price, whether your water comes from a tap or a well, and whether your property tax includes a metropolitan district on top of everything else. Those are the differences that decide whether you like living here. Almost none of them show up in listing photos.

So this guide is organised the way the decision actually gets made: town by town, on the four things people ask me about before they ask about houses — the schools, the drive, what is being built, and what it costs.

Why I am the one writing this

I left Loveland, and then I chose to come back. That is a more useful credential for this particular document than any sales figure, because it means I have actually made the decision you are making, in both directions. I will tell you when a different town is the better fit — including the ones I do not personally love.

For the record: Christine Gwinnup, Signature Property Collection, LPT Realty. RealTrends Verified in the top 0.5% of Realtors nationwide, 250+ homes sold as a duo with Kendra Bajcar, and \$200M+ in combined volume across Northern Colorado.

How to use it

Read the region overview, then skip straight to the counties you are considering. The comparison table near the back is the fastest way to narrow thirty towns to four. Once you have four, the town profiles tell you what living in each one is actually like.

THE LAY OF THE LAND

How Northern Colorado is laid out

Everything here hangs off one line: Interstate 25, running north–south along the Front Range. Denver sits at the south end, the Wyoming line at the north. Almost every town in this guide is defined by how far it is from that highway and which direction it sits from it.

West of I-25 is the foothills side — Loveland, Fort Collins, Berthoud, and behind them the canyon and mountain communities like Masonville, Red Feather Lakes, Estes Park and Lyons. Closer to the mountains means views, acreage, cooler summers, and a real conversation about wildfire insurance, wells and septic.

East of I-25 is the plains side — Windsor, Timnath, Severance, Wellington, Eaton, Greeley and out toward Morgan County. This is where most of the new construction is, which means newer homes, more land per dollar, master-planned neighbourhoods, and metropolitan districts.

South along I-25 the region blends into the Denver metro — Erie, Frederick, Firestone, Dacono, Mead, Longmont, and Boulder County. People who work in Denver or Boulder but want Northern Colorado prices tend to land in this band.

Two practical consequences. First, "Northern Colorado" is not one market — a Boulder County buyer and a Weld County buyer are shopping in different worlds. Second, your commute is decided less by miles than by which side of I-25 you are on and which highway you feed onto.

The counties, briefly

County	What defines it
Larimer County	Fort Collins and Loveland anchor it. Foothills access, Colorado State University, the most established in-town neighbourhoods, and the mountain communities behind them.
Weld County	The growth engine. Windsor, Timnath, Severance, Eaton, Greeley. Most of the region's new construction, the most land per dollar, and the highest likelihood of a metro district.
Boulder County	Boulder, Longmont, Louisville, Lafayette, Lyons, Nederland. The most expensive tier in this guide and the strongest Denver/Boulder job access.
Broomfield, Denver, Adams, Arapahoe, Jefferson	The southern end, where Northern Colorado becomes the Denver metro. Included because the commute question runs both ways.
Morgan County	Fort Morgan, Brush, Wiggins, Log Lane Village. Further east and genuinely rural, at prices nothing on the Front Range matches.

TOWN BY TOWN

What living in each town is like

All 36 towns, grouped by county. Every school district and commute figure below is the same data the town pages on my website carry, which means it is maintained rather than typed once into a PDF. Where a town is growing fast or something specific is being built, that is noted — those are the facts that change what a place feels like in five years.

One caution on schools. The district serves the town; attendance boundaries decide which school a specific address feeds into, and they do not follow town lines. If a particular school is driving your move, send me the shortlist and I will check the boundary on each address before you tour it.

LARIMER COUNTY

Fort Collins

Fort Collins is a vibrant and welcoming city in Northern Colorado, nestled at the foothills of the Rocky Mountains.

Schools: Poudre School District R-1

Commute: About 64 miles / roughly 1 hour 17 minutes to Denver via I-25 (longer with typical traffic); about 20 miles / 37 minutes to Berthoud, and roughly 10 miles to Timnath.

Loveland

Loveland, Colorado, is a charming city celebrated for its artistic vibe, scenic beauty, and warm community spirit.

Schools: Thompson School District R2-J

Commute: About 51 miles / roughly 1 hour 4 minutes to Denver via I-25; about 33 miles / roughly 49 minutes to Boulder via CO-119.

Worth knowing: Loveland hosts Sculpture in the Park each August at Benson Park, one of the largest outdoor fine-art sculpture shows in the country — a signature annual event tied to the city's arts-town identity.

Estes Park

Estes Park sits at the eastern gateway to Rocky Mountain National Park, and that single fact shapes everything about living here — the views, the seasons, the economy and the housing market.

Schools: Estes Park School District R-3

Commute: About 40 minutes to Loveland via US-34 through the Big Thompson Canyon — the nearest full-service city — and roughly an hour and a half to Denver. Worth being honest about: the canyon is a beautiful drive and it is also the only practical route east, so winter weather, rockfall closures and summer visitor traffic all land on the same road. Anyone planning a daily Front Range commute should drive it in February before deciding.

Worth knowing: Estes Park's market behaves differently from the rest of Larimer County. Inventory is small, a meaningful share of it is second homes and vacation rentals, and short-term rental licensing is limited and regulated by the town — so whether a given property can legally be rented nightly is a question to answer before making an offer, not after. Christine has helped clients buy and sell here many times and knows which streets hold value through the off-season.

Berthoud

Berthoud, Colorado, is a picturesque town often called the “Garden Spot of Colorado” for its lush landscapes and tree-lined streets.

Schools: Thompson School District R2-J

Commute: About 7 miles (12 min) to Loveland, 20 miles (37 min) to Fort Collins via US-287, and roughly 46 miles (about 56 min) to Denver via I-25.

Worth knowing: Berthoud is one of the faster-growing towns in Larimer County, with active master-planned new-home communities such as Berthoud Harvest and Farmstead adding significant new-construction inventory to a historically small-town market.

Masonville

Masonville is a small unincorporated community tucked into the foothills of western Larimer County, between Fort Collins and Loveland near Horsetooth Reservoir and Masonville Falls.

Schools: Thompson School District R2-J

Commute: About 15 miles (30 min) to Fort Collins and about 12 miles (25 min) to Loveland via county roads — both easy day-trip commutes for an unincorporated foothills community.

Worth knowing: Real estate in Masonville skews toward large rural acreage rather than typical subdivision lots — the Redstone Canyon neighborhood, for example, originated from ranches subdivided into 40-acre parcels in the late 1960s — so buyers should expect well-and-septic, larger-lot living rather than municipal utilities.

Windsor

Windsor, Colorado, is a thriving community that blends small-town warmth with modern amenities.

Schools: Weld RE-4 School District

Commute: About 17 miles / 27 minutes to Fort Collins via CO-14, and about 15 miles / 27 minutes to Greeley via US-34 Business — a genuine dual-commute town.

Worth knowing: Windsor was Colorado's fastest-growing town among communities of 20,000+ residents, posting 23.3% population growth from April 2020 to July 2023.

Timnath

Timnath, Colorado, is a peaceful and rapidly growing town that perfectly balances small-town charm with modern living.

Schools: Poudre School District R-1

Commute: About 10 miles (17 min) to Fort Collins via CO-14, and about 57 miles (roughly 1 hour 7 minutes) to Denver via I-25.

Worth knowing: Timnath's rapid growth is almost entirely master-planned-community development (WildWing, Timnath Ranch), and most of these communities layer both an HOA and a metropolitan district on top of base property taxes — a real budgeting factor for relocating buyers.

Wellington

Wellington, Colorado, is a quaint and welcoming town known for its friendly atmosphere and strong community ties.

Schools: Poudre School District R-1 (Wellington Middle-High School serves the town)

Commute: About 14 miles / roughly 20 minutes to Fort Collins via CO-1, Wellington's main commute corridor and primary job center.

Worth knowing: Wellington broke ground in 2025 on the 300-acre Sage Farms master-planned residential community, the Wellington Business Center retail/restaurant development, and a 50,000+ sq ft manufacturing facility — a shift from bedroom community toward more local jobs and amenities.

Red Feather Lakes

Red Feather Lakes, Colorado, is a serene mountain village offering a peaceful retreat surrounded by breathtaking natural beauty.

Schools: Poudre School District R-1 (local schooling via PSD's Mountain Schools cluster, including Red Feather Lakes Elementary; older students bus toward Fort Collins/Laporte schools)

Commute: About 45 miles / roughly 1 hour 10 minutes to Fort Collins via CR 74E — the primary commute route and nearest job center.

Worth knowing: Real estate here is dominated by well-and-septic, large-acreage mountain and cabin lots (often 1+ acres, many seasonal or off-grid) — a distinctly different buyer profile than the platted town lots common down on the plains.

WELD COUNTY

Greeley

Greeley, Colorado, is a vibrant city with a rich history and a thriving cultural scene.

Schools: Greeley-Evans School District 6

Commute: About 32 miles / 45-50 minutes to Fort Collins via US-34; about 57-63 miles / roughly 1 hour to Denver via I-25 or US-85.

Worth knowing: Weld County was Colorado's fastest-growing large county in 2025, surpassing Larimer County in total population for the first time.

Severance

Severance, Colorado, is a charming and rapidly growing town nestled in Northern Colorado.

Schools: Weld RE-4 (Windsor)

Commute: About 16 miles / 27 minutes to Fort Collins via CO-14.

Worth knowing: Severance is one of Weld County's fastest-growing communities, reflecting continued new-home construction in and around town.

Eaton

Eaton, Colorado, is a welcoming agricultural town with a rich history and a strong sense of community.

Schools: Weld RE-2 School District (Eaton School District)

Commute: About 9 miles / roughly 15-17 minutes to Greeley via US-85, Eaton's primary job center.

Worth knowing: Eaton hosts Eaton Days, its signature annual community festival — a good small-town-camaraderie selling point for relocation buyers.

Ault

Ault is a small, close-knit agricultural town in Weld County, sitting along US Highway 85 just a few miles north of Eaton and about 12 miles north of Greeley.

Schools: Weld RE-9 School District (Ault-Highland)

Commute: About 12 miles / roughly 15-18 minutes to Greeley via US-85, Ault's nearest job center.

Worth knowing: Ault is a classic agricultural/ranching plains town — real estate leans toward larger lots on well-and-septic with agricultural zoning just outside town limits, appealing to buyers wanting acreage and rural character within a short drive of Greeley.

Johnstown

Johnstown, Colorado, is a charming and rapidly growing town that perfectly blends small-town warmth with modern conveniences.

Schools: Weld RE-5J (Johnstown-Milliken School District)

Commute: About 12 miles / 21 minutes to Loveland via CO-402; about 47 miles / under an hour to Denver via I-25.

Worth knowing: The adjacent Centerra South development has been rebranded Avenue South, with new construction underway as of 2026, adding to Johnstown-area retail and residential growth.

Milliken

Milliken, Colorado, is a peaceful and welcoming town known for its close-knit community and small-town charm.

Schools: Weld RE-5J (Johnstown-Milliken School District)

Commute: About 14 miles / 27 minutes to Greeley via US-34 Business; about 15 miles / 27 minutes to Loveland via CO-60.

Worth knowing: Milliken sits within Weld County's high-growth corridor — the county was Colorado's fastest-growing large county in 2025, adding nearly 50,000 residents since 2020.

Firestone

Firestone, Colorado, is a vibrant and family-friendly town known for its stunning mountain views and welcoming community.

Schools: St. Vrain Valley Schools (includes Firestone Charter Academy, feeds into Frederick High School)

Commute: About 30 miles / 41 minutes to Denver via I-25, and roughly 12-15 minutes to Longmont — dual access to Denver and Boulder-area jobs.

Worth knowing: Firestone is part of the strongest growth pocket in Weld County (alongside Frederick, Dacono, and Erie), driven by relative affordability compared to Boulder County and metro Denver.

Frederick

Frederick, Colorado, is a dynamic and growing town that combines small-town charm with modern living.

Schools: St. Vrain Valley Schools (feeds into Frederick High School)

Commute: About 28 miles / 28-37 minutes to Denver and roughly 22 miles / 34 minutes to Boulder — a fairly balanced commute to both metro job centers.

Worth knowing: Frederick is one of the fastest-growing towns in the region, up roughly 30% since the 2020 census, fueled by Denver/Boulder-area buyers seeking affordability.

Dacono

Dacono, Colorado, is a charming and close-knit community offering a relaxed, small-town vibe.

Schools: St. Vrain Valley School District RE-1J

Commute: About 28 miles / 39 minutes to Denver via I-25, with direct I-25 access into both Denver and Boulder.

Worth knowing: Dacono is one of the fastest-growing towns in southern Weld County — population rose over 51% from 2010 to 2020 — driven largely by Denver/Boulder-area buyers seeking more affordable housing.

Fort Lupton

Fort Lupton, Colorado, is a historic and welcoming town nestled along the South Platte River.

Schools: Weld RE-8 School District, headquartered in Fort Lupton

Commute: About 29 miles / 43 minutes to Denver via US-85 — a direct north-south commute route into the metro area without needing I-25.

Worth knowing: Fort Lupton has grown more modestly than its neighboring I-25-corridor towns, which may appeal to buyers wanting a quieter, more historic South Platte River town within commuting range of Denver.

Mead

Mead, Colorado, is a tranquil and friendly town that captures the essence of small-town living.

Schools: St. Vrain Valley School District RE-1J

Commute: About 13 miles / 18 minutes to Longmont via I-25; about 17 miles / 24 minutes to Loveland via I-25.

Erie

Erie, Colorado, is a vibrant town that blends small-town charm with modern amenities and a lively community spirit.

Schools: St. Vrain Valley Schools serves most of Erie (including Erie High School); a portion of town falls in Boulder Valley School District (BVSD) depending on the neighborhood

Commute: About 27 miles / 39 minutes to Denver via I-25, and roughly 15-18 miles to Boulder — within a reasonable daily commute of both job centers.

Worth knowing: Erie is one of the southern Weld County towns seeing outsized growth from buyers priced out of Boulder County and metro Denver.

Nunn

Nunn is a town of about 550 people on US-85 north of Greeley, and it is one of the few places on the northern Front Range where acreage is still genuinely attainable.

Schools: Weld RE-9 School District (Highland — serving Ault, Pierce, Nunn and Carr)

Commute: About 21 miles to Greeley via US-85 and CR 29, and about 25 miles to Fort Collins. Both are real commutes rather than errands, and the school district — Weld RE-9, known locally as Highland — runs bus routes across 539 square miles, which tells you something honest about the distances out here.

Worth knowing: If you are buying land in Nunn, this is the part that matters more than the house. A property here is not a subdivision lot: there are wells and well permits, septic systems and their condition, water rights, survey lines, easements and legal access, utility distances, county zoning, and rules on how many animals you may keep and where. Every one of those can change what a parcel is worth or whether you can do the thing you bought it for. If shooting is part of why you are looking out here, note that Great Guns Sporting sits on County Road 96, which is a genuine amenity to some buyers and something to know about in advance for others — it is an outdoor range, and sound carries a long way across open prairie. Many Nunn properties are also USDA-eligible, which can mean no down payment — genuinely useful, and it comes with its own conditions. Christine has listed and sold acreage in and around Nunn repeatedly and will walk the property with you asking these questions before you write an offer, not after.

Pierce

Pierce is a town of about 1,100 people on US-85, sixteen miles north of Greeley and twenty-one from Fort Collins by way of CO-14.

Schools: Weld RE-9 School District (Highland — serving Ault, Pierce, Nunn and Carr)

Commute: 16 miles to Greeley on US-85, and 21 miles to Fort Collins via CO-14. Both are genuine twenty-to-thirty-minute commutes on open road rather than stop-and-go, which is the trade Pierce offers: you drive further and you drive faster. Highland's schools are in Ault, a few minutes south, and Weld RE-9 runs bus routes across 539 square miles.

Worth knowing: Pierce is small enough that inventory is thin — some months there is very little for sale, and a house that fits you may not be listed the week you start looking. That cuts both ways: it is also why a well-marketed listing here does not sit. Christine has sold three homes in Pierce, including 14775 County Road 88 and two on 4th Street, so she knows what the buyer pool actually looks like and what it pays. If you are looking at acreage outside the town limits, the questions change entirely — wells, septic, water rights, legal access — and those are worth walking the property for before you write an offer.

Carr

Carr is an unincorporated community in far northern Weld County, settled in 1872 and sitting almost exactly halfway between Fort Collins and Cheyenne — 32 miles to the first, 22 to the second.

Schools: Weld RE-9 School District (Highland — serving Ault, Pierce, Nunn and Carr)

Commute: 32 miles to Fort Collins and 22 miles to Cheyenne, with I-25 reached via County Road 126. Carr is the closest community to the halfway point between those two cities, which is the practical case for living here: two job markets in two states inside a half-hour each. Be clear-eyed about the school run, though — Highland's schools are in Ault, and Weld RE-9's bus routes cover 539 square miles for a reason.

Worth knowing: Buying in Carr is buying land, and the house is often the smaller half of the decision. Wells and well permits, septic condition, water rights, survey lines, easements and legal access, how far power and fiber actually run, county zoning, and how many animals you may keep and where — every one of those can change what a parcel is worth or whether you can do the thing you bought it for. Many properties out here are USDA-eligible, which can mean no money down, and that comes with its own conditions. Christine has sold acreage in Carr — 54175 County Road 27 among them — and will walk the ground with you asking these questions before you write an offer, not after.

BOULDER COUNTY

Boulder

Boulder, Colorado, is a vibrant city renowned for its stunning natural beauty, progressive culture, and outdoor lifestyle.

Schools: Boulder Valley School District (BVSD, Re-2)

Commute: About 33 miles / roughly 48 minutes to Loveland via US-36 and CO-119.

Worth knowing: Boulder's market is tight and ultra-premium: median single-family price runs roughly \$1.05M-\$1.15M with limited active inventory, and luxury demand concentrates in neighborhoods like Mapleton Hill and Wonderland Hills — partly a result of Boulder's building-height limits and city-owned open space greenbelt constraining new supply.

Longmont

Longmont is the practical answer to Boulder.

Schools: St. Vrain Valley Schools (RE-1J)

Commute: About 16 miles to Boulder, and roughly 33 miles / about 43 minutes to Denver. St. Vrain Valley Schools, which serves the city, is Colorado's seventh largest district — around 33,000 students across 60 schools and 411 square miles — so school choice here is a genuine consideration rather than a formality.

Worth knowing: Longmont is where a lot of Boulder County buying decisions actually land. Sixteen miles buys materially more house than the same money does in Boulder, the downtown is real, and the commute is short enough that people do it for years. Two things to establish about any specific address: which county it sits in, since Longmont straddles the Boulder/Weld line, and how close it is to the St. Vrain corridor — the 2013 flood reached parts of Longmont too, and floodplain designation affects insurance and resale here just as it does upstream in Lyons.

Lafayette

Lafayette, Colorado, is a charming and vibrant city that perfectly blends small-town warmth with modern amenities.

Schools: Boulder Valley School District (BVSD, Re-2)

Commute: About 30 miles / roughly 43 minutes to Loveland via US-287/CO-7.

Worth knowing: Lafayette is often positioned as the relative value play inside Boulder Valley School District — same district access as Boulder and Louisville, typically at a lower price point.

Louisville

Louisville, Colorado, is a picturesque city celebrated for its friendly community, scenic beauty, and high quality of life.

Schools: Boulder Valley School District (BVSD, Re-2)

Commute: About 32 miles / roughly 48 minutes to Loveland via US-287.

Worth knowing: Louisville has a well-documented history of national "Best Places to Live" recognition, a reputation that continues to support strong buyer demand and price premiums relative to nearby towns.

Nederland

Nederland, Colorado, is a quaint mountain town known for its rich history, artistic spirit, and stunning natural surroundings.

Schools: Boulder Valley School District (BVSD, Re-2) — served locally by Nederland Elementary and Nederland Middle-Senior High School

Commute: About 49 miles / roughly 1 hour 20 minutes to Loveland via CO-119/US-36; about 17 miles / roughly 32 minutes to Boulder.

Worth knowing: Nederland's town board approved a roughly \$120M purchase of Eldora Mountain Resort from POWDR Corporation (approved January 2026) — if finalized, Eldora would become a rare community/municipally-owned ski resort, a distinctive story for buyers drawn to mountain-town character.

Lyons

Lyons sits where the North and South St.

Schools: St. Vrain Valley Schools (Lyons Elementary and Lyons Middle/Senior High)

Commute: About 12 miles / roughly 20 minutes to Longmont via US-36 and CO-66, and about 17 miles / roughly 30 minutes to Boulder — close enough that Lyons works as a real commuter base, far enough that it does not feel like one. Estes Park and Rocky Mountain National Park are up CO-7 from town.

Worth knowing: One thing to understand about Lyons before making an offer. The September 2013 flood sent both branches of the St. Vrain through the middle of town, destroying homes, businesses and the festival grounds and displacing thousands of people. The town rebuilt and is thriving — but floodplain designation, flood insurance requirements and what was rebuilt when are real questions on any property near the creeks, and they materially affect cost and resale. Ask them before you write an offer, not after inspection. Christine works throughout Boulder County and will tell you plainly which properties carry that question and which do not.

BROOMFIELD COUNTY

Broomfield

Broomfield, Colorado, is a vibrant city offering a perfect mix of small-town charm and modern amenities.

Schools: Adams 12 Five Star Schools (primary district for most of the city; a portion of northwest Broomfield falls in Boulder Valley School District Re-2)

Commute: About 42 miles / roughly 45-50 minutes to Loveland, largely via US-287/I-25.

Worth knowing: Baseline, a large master-planned community between Denver and Boulder, is actively selling new-construction homes from the \$500s to \$1M+, with a walkable retail district and a new park slated to open in 2027.

DENVER COUNTY

Denver

Denver, Colorado, is a vibrant urban center celebrated for its rich history, cultural diversity, and breathtaking views of the Rocky Mountains.

Schools: Denver Public Schools (DPS)

Commute: About 51-52 miles to Loveland, entirely on I-25, typically 55-70 minutes depending on metro traffic.

Worth knowing: Denver's close-in, walkable neighborhoods (Highlands/LoHi/RiNo) are among the city's highest-demand, highest-premium pockets, appealing to buyers who want dense urban walkability without leaving city limits.

MORGAN COUNTY

Fort Morgan

Fort Morgan is the Morgan County seat and the largest town on I-76 between Greeley and the Nebraska line — 11,597 people at the 2020 census, wrapped around a bend in the South Platte River about 80 miles northeast of Denver.

Schools: Morgan County School District Re-3

Commute: About 83 miles and an hour and a half to Denver on I-76, about 53 miles and an hour to Greeley on US-34, and about 84 miles to Fort Collins. Worth saying plainly: this is a town people commute within rather than out of — Cargill, Leprino Foods, Western Sugar, Colorado Plains Medical Center and Morgan Community College are all inside the city.

Worth knowing: Fort Morgan's economy is food processing and agriculture, and that shapes the housing market more than any Front Range trend does. Cargill's beef plant is the county's largest employer at roughly 2,100 people, Leprino Foods' cheese plant employs several hundred more, and the Western Sugar Cooperative plant here is the last operating sugar-beet processing plant in Colorado. For a buyer that means steady year-round rental demand and a housing stock with real range — brick and frame homes in the older grid near downtown, mid-century neighborhoods, newer subdivisions on the edges, and farm and ranch acreage outside the city limits where well and septic replace municipal utilities.

Brush

Brush sits 11 miles east of Fort Morgan on I-76 — close enough to share Fort Morgan's shopping and hospital runs, far enough to be unmistakably its own town.

Schools: Brush School District RE-2(J)

Commute: About 11 miles and 15 minutes to Fort Morgan on I-76, about 92 miles and an hour and forty minutes to Denver, and about 94 miles to Fort Collins. East Morgan County Hospital is in town on West Edison Street; the larger Colorado Plains Medical Center is in Fort Morgan.

Worth knowing: For families already living in the county, the schools are Brush's practical draw: the district opened the Brush Secondary Campus in 2019, housing Brush Middle School and Brush High School together in one modern building, and enrolls roughly 1,400 students across four schools — small enough that a kid who wants to be on a team is on the team. Housing runs older and more attainable than the Front Range norm, with historic homes near downtown, post-war and newer subdivisions filling in around them, and irrigated acreage in every direction once you're past city limits.

Wiggins

Wiggins is the Morgan County town closest to Denver, and the one that has changed the most.

Schools: Wiggins School District RE-50(J)

Commute: About an hour to Denver on I-76 and under an hour to both Denver International Airport and Greeley — the shortest Front Range commute of any Morgan County town — plus about 15 miles and 20 minutes east to Fort Morgan.

Worth knowing: Wiggins is where Morgan County's new construction actually is. Kiowa Park has been built out by a mix of local and regional builders — Baessler Homes, Low Energy Homes, King Family Construction, 2 Valley Builders and Tru-Grit NoCo among them — so a buyer can still find a genuinely new house here at a price that no longer exists in Weld County's I-25 corridor. Two things worth asking before you write an offer: what the water and sewer connection situation is for the specific lot, and how the district is planning for growth, since one campus serves the entire town.

Log Lane Village

Log Lane Village is a statutory town of about 900 people (913 at the 2020 census), incorporated in 1956 and named for the log houses it started as, at the crossroads of Highway 144 and I-76 about two miles northwest of Fort Morgan.

Schools: Morgan County School District Re-3 (Fort Morgan)

Commute: Two miles to Fort Morgan, about 83 miles and an hour and a half to Denver on I-76, and about 55 miles to Greeley — functionally the same commute as Fort Morgan's, with the interstate on-ramp right there at the Highway 144 interchange.

Worth knowing: Log Lane Village is worth understanding before buying into it. It's its own municipality rather than part of Fort Morgan, with its own town hall, ordinances and utility service, so water, sewer and trash come from the town — ask what the monthly utility bill actually runs, and whether the specific lot is on town water and sewer, because this is an older small-lot town and that detail varies house to house. Children attend Morgan County School District Re-3 schools in Fort Morgan. And know the local character going in: four retail marijuana dispensaries in a town of 900 is a defining feature of the place, and the town lists them among its primary businesses.

NARROW IT DOWN

Schools and commute, at a glance

The fastest way to get from thirty towns to four. Find the school districts you would accept, then read the commute column.

Town	County	School district	Commute
Fort Collins	Larimer	Poudre School District R-1	About 64 miles / roughly 1 hour 17 minutes to Denver via I-25 (longer with typical traffic); about 20 miles / 37 minutes to Berthoud, and roughly 10 miles to Timnath.
Loveland	Larimer	Thompson School District R2-J	About 51 miles / roughly 1 hour 4 minutes to Denver via I-25; about 33 miles / roughly 49 minutes to Boulder via CO-119.
Estes Park	Larimer	Estes Park School District R-3	About 40 minutes to Loveland via US-34 through the Big Thompson Canyon — the nearest full-service city — and roughly an hour and a half to Denver. Worth being honest about: the canyon is a beautiful drive and it is also the only practical route east, so winter weather, rockfall closures and summer visitor traffic all land on the same road. Anyone planning a daily Front Range commute should drive it in February before deciding.
Berthoud	Larimer	Thompson School District R2-J	About 7 miles (12 min) to Loveland, 20 miles (37 min) to Fort Collins via US-287, and roughly 46 miles (about 56 min) to Denver via I-25.
Masonville	Larimer	Thompson School District R2-J	About 15 miles (30 min) to Fort Collins and about 12 miles (25 min) to Loveland via county roads — both easy day-trip commutes for an unincorporated foothills community.
Windsor	Larimer	Weld RE-4 School District	About 17 miles / 27 minutes to Fort Collins via CO-14, and about 15 miles / 27 minutes to Greeley via US-34 Business — a genuine dual-commute town.
Timnath	Larimer	Poudre School District R-1	About 10 miles (17 min) to Fort Collins via CO-14, and about 57 miles (roughly 1 hour 7 minutes) to Denver via I-25.
Wellington	Larimer	Poudre School District R-1 (Wellington Middle-High School serves the town)	About 14 miles / roughly 20 minutes to Fort Collins via CO-1, Wellington's main commute corridor and primary job center.
Red Feather Lakes	Larimer	Poudre School District R-1 (local schooling via PSD's Mountain Schools cluster, including Red Feather Lakes Elementary; older students bus toward Fort Collins/Laporte schools)	About 45 miles / roughly 1 hour 10 minutes to Fort Collins via CR 74E — the primary commute route and nearest job center.

Town	County	School district	Commute
Greeley	Weld	Greeley-Evans School District 6	About 32 miles / 45-50 minutes to Fort Collins via US-34; about 57-63 miles / roughly 1 hour to Denver via I-25 or US-85.
Severance	Weld	Weld RE-4 (Windsor)	About 16 miles / 27 minutes to Fort Collins via CO-14.
Eaton	Weld	Weld RE-2 School District (Eaton School District)	About 9 miles / roughly 15-17 minutes to Greeley via US-85, Eaton's primary job center.
Ault	Weld	Weld RE-9 School District (Ault-Highland)	About 12 miles / roughly 15-18 minutes to Greeley via US-85, Ault's nearest job center.
Johnstown	Weld	Weld RE-5J (Johnstown-Milliken School District)	About 12 miles / 21 minutes to Loveland via CO-402; about 47 miles / under an hour to Denver via I-25.
Milliken	Weld	Weld RE-5J (Johnstown-Milliken School District)	About 14 miles / 27 minutes to Greeley via US-34 Business; about 15 miles / 27 minutes to Loveland via CO-60.
Firestone	Weld	St. Vrain Valley Schools (includes Firestone Charter Academy, feeds into Frederick High School)	About 30 miles / 41 minutes to Denver via I-25, and roughly 12-15 minutes to Longmont — dual access to Denver and Boulder-area jobs.
Frederick	Weld	St. Vrain Valley Schools (feeds into Frederick High School)	About 28 miles / 28-37 minutes to Denver and roughly 22 miles / 34 minutes to Boulder — a fairly balanced commute to both metro job centers.
Dacono	Weld	St. Vrain Valley School District RE-1J	About 28 miles / 39 minutes to Denver via I-25, with direct I-25 access into both Denver and Boulder.
Fort Lupton	Weld	Weld RE-8 School District, headquartered in Fort Lupton	About 29 miles / 43 minutes to Denver via US-85 — a direct north-south commute route into the metro area without needing I-25.
Mead	Weld	St. Vrain Valley School District RE-1J	About 13 miles / 18 minutes to Longmont via I-25; about 17 miles / 24 minutes to Loveland via I-25.
Erie	Weld	St. Vrain Valley Schools serves most of Erie (including Erie High School); a portion of town falls in Boulder Valley School District (BVSD) depending on the neighborhood	About 27 miles / 39 minutes to Denver via I-25, and roughly 15-18 miles to Boulder — within a reasonable daily commute of both job centers.
Nunn	Weld	Weld RE-9 School District (Highland — serving Ault, Pierce, Nunn and Carr)	About 21 miles to Greeley via US-85 and CR 29, and about 25 miles to Fort Collins. Both are real commutes rather than errands, and the school district — Weld RE-9, known locally as Highland — runs bus routes across 539 square miles, which tells you something honest about the distances out here.

Town	County	School district	Commute
Pierce	Weld	Weld RE-9 School District (Highland — serving Ault, Pierce, Nunn and Carr)	16 miles to Greeley on US-85, and 21 miles to Fort Collins via CO-14. Both are genuine twenty-to-thirty-minute commutes on open road rather than stop-and-go, which is the trade Pierce offers: you drive further and you drive faster. Highland's schools are in Ault, a few minutes south, and Weld RE-9 runs bus routes across 539 square miles.
Carr	Weld	Weld RE-9 School District (Highland — serving Ault, Pierce, Nunn and Carr)	32 miles to Fort Collins and 22 miles to Cheyenne, with I-25 reached via County Road 126. Carr is the closest community to the halfway point between those two cities, which is the practical case for living here: two job markets in two states inside a half-hour each. Be clear-eyed about the school run, though — Highland's schools are in Ault, and Weld RE-9's bus routes cover 539 square miles for a reason.
Boulder	Boulder	Boulder Valley School District (BVSD, Re-2)	About 33 miles / roughly 48 minutes to Loveland via US-36 and CO-119.
Longmont	Boulder	St. Vrain Valley Schools (RE-1J)	About 16 miles to Boulder, and roughly 33 miles / about 43 minutes to Denver. St. Vrain Valley Schools, which serves the city, is Colorado's seventh largest district — around 33,000 students across 60 schools and 411 square miles — so school choice here is a genuine consideration rather than a formality.
Lafayette	Boulder	Boulder Valley School District (BVSD, Re-2)	About 30 miles / roughly 43 minutes to Loveland via US-287/CO-7.
Louisville	Boulder	Boulder Valley School District (BVSD, Re-2)	About 32 miles / roughly 48 minutes to Loveland via US-287.
Nederland	Boulder	Boulder Valley School District (BVSD, Re-2) — served locally by Nederland Elementary and Nederland Middle-Senior High School	About 49 miles / roughly 1 hour 20 minutes to Loveland via CO-119/US-36; about 17 miles / roughly 32 minutes to Boulder.
Lyons	Boulder	St. Vrain Valley Schools (Lyons Elementary and Lyons Middle/Senior High)	About 12 miles / roughly 20 minutes to Longmont via US-36 and CO-66, and about 17 miles / roughly 30 minutes to Boulder — close enough that Lyons works as a real commuter base, far enough that it does not feel like one. Estes Park and Rocky Mountain National Park are up CO-7 from town.
Broomfield	Broomfield	Adams 12 Five Star Schools (primary district for most of the city; a portion of northwest Broomfield falls in Boulder Valley School District Re-2)	About 42 miles / roughly 45-50 minutes to Loveland, largely via US-287/I-25.

Town	County	School district	Commute
Denver	Denver	Denver Public Schools (DPS)	About 51-52 miles to Loveland, entirely on I-25, typically 55-70 minutes depending on metro traffic.
Fort Morgan	Morgan	Morgan County School District Re-3	About 83 miles and an hour and a half to Denver on I-76, about 53 miles and an hour to Greeley on US-34, and about 84 miles to Fort Collins. Worth saying plainly: this is a town people commute within rather than out of — Cargill, Leprino Foods, Western Sugar, Colorado Plains Medical Center and Morgan Community College are all inside the city.
Brush	Morgan	Brush School District RE-2(J)	About 11 miles and 15 minutes to Fort Morgan on I-76, about 92 miles and an hour and forty minutes to Denver, and about 94 miles to Fort Collins. East Morgan County Hospital is in town on West Edison Street; the larger Colorado Plains Medical Center is in Fort Morgan.
Wiggins	Morgan	Wiggins School District RE-50(J)	About an hour to Denver on I-76 and under an hour to both Denver International Airport and Greeley — the shortest Front Range commute of any Morgan County town — plus about 15 miles and 20 minutes east to Fort Morgan.
Log Lane Village	Morgan	Morgan County School District Re-3 (Fort Morgan)	Two miles to Fort Morgan, about 83 miles and an hour and a half to Denver on I-76, and about 55 miles to Greeley — functionally the same commute as Fort Morgan's, with the interstate on-ramp right there at the Highway 144 interchange.

THE PROCESS

Buying from a thousand miles away

Roughly half my business is people who do not live here yet. The process works, but it works differently from buying across town, and the difference is mostly about sequencing.

Make the first trip a scouting trip, not a shopping trip

The instinct is to fly in and look at houses. That wastes the trip. On a first visit we drive towns, not listings — you spend a day feeling the difference between the foothills side and the plains side, sitting in the actual commute at the actual hour, walking two or three downtowns. People who do this eliminate half the map in one day and stop second-guessing later.

Then tour on one focused trip

Once you know the town, we line up showings in a tight block, with video walkthroughs on anything that comes up between visits. I film honestly — including the road noise and the neighbour's RV — because a video that flatters a house wastes a flight.

Writing an offer on a house you have not stood in

It happens constantly here and it is survivable, with two protections: a real inspection period, and a walkthrough clause that lets you out if the house is materially not what the video showed. What you should not do is waive inspection to win a bidding war on a home you have only seen on a screen. In this market that is rarely what wins anyway — pricing and terms usually matter more than speed.

Lending, before anything else

Get fully underwritten with a lender who has actually closed Colorado loans, not just pre-qualified. Out-of-state buyers get beaten by local buyers on identical offers when the lender is an unknown quantity to the listing agent. I am happy to hand you two or three names; I do not take a referral fee on any of them.

Timing the two ends

Selling there and buying here rarely lines up cleanly. Bridge financing, a rent-back to the seller, or a short-term rental on this end are all normal. Decide which one you are willing to live with before you are under contract, not during.

The Colorado-specific line items

These are the things that catch people moving in from other states — not because anyone hides them, but because they do not exist where you are coming from.

Water is its own subject

In much of this region, especially on acreage, water is not simply "connected." A property may be on a municipal tap, a rural water district, or a private well — and well permits carry real limits on what you may use the water for. A household-use-only permit does not let you irrigate pasture or water livestock. If your plan involves horses, a garden of any ambition, or anything green in August, the permit type matters as much as the acreage. Irrigation shares and ditch rights are a separate matter again, and they do not automatically travel with the land.

Septic, and the inspection at transfer

Plenty of homes out here are on a septic system rather than sewer. Counties in this region generally require an inspection of the system when a property changes hands, and a failed system can be a five-figure repair. The rules are set county by county and do change, so I confirm the current requirement for the specific county before we are under contract rather than relying on what was true last year.

Metropolitan districts — the tax nobody mentions

This is the single most common unpleasant surprise in new construction here. Many master-planned neighbourhoods, particularly in Weld County, sit inside a metropolitan district that levies an additional mill levy on your property tax to pay off the infrastructure bonds — on top of any HOA dues. Two identical houses in two neighbourhoods can carry materially different annual costs for this reason alone. It is disclosed, it is legal, and it is easy to miss. Ask for the mill levy and the district's debt service on anything new, and read it next to the HOA budget.

Radon

Much of the Front Range sits in a high-radon area. This is normal here and mitigation is routine and not expensive relative to the house. Test during your inspection period; do not skip it because the seller says the basement is dry. Those are unrelated facts.

Wildfire, and what it does to insurance

If you are looking at the foothills or canyon communities — Masonville, Red Feather Lakes, Estes Park, Lyons, Nederland — get an insurance quote before you fall in love, not after. Availability and pricing in higher-risk areas have tightened considerably, and it is far better to learn that while you still have options than during your contract.

Altitude, and the things it quietly affects

Swamp coolers instead of air conditioning in older homes. Sun exposure that ages roofs, decks and exterior paint faster than you expect. Hail — this is one of the more active hail corridors in the country, so roof age and material belong on your diligence list, and so does the difference between replacement cost and actual cash value on the policy.

WHAT IT COSTS

Why there is no price table in this guide

You will find other relocation guides for this area with a median price printed in them. Check the date on those numbers. A median typed into a PDF is accurate for about a month and then it is just decoration — and you would be making a six-figure decision on it.

My website solves this differently. It reads the IRES MLS feed directly, so every town page carries that town's live active inventory and its current median asking price, recomputed as listings change rather than typed in once. That is the number worth having, and it cannot live in a document you downloaded in August.

Where to look instead

Any town page — Live active listing count and median asking price for that specific town, plus schools, commute and what is being built.

<https://signaturepropertycollection.com/communities/index.html>

The monthly market report — Regional medians, days on market and sale-to-list, updated monthly — and the page tells you how old the figures are instead of pretending to be current.

<https://signaturepropertycollection.com/northern-colorado-market-report.html>

Search homes — Every active listing in the region, filterable, straight from the MLS.

<https://signaturepropertycollection.com/search-homes.html>

Asking prices are not sale prices. What homes actually close for is in the monthly report, and the gap between the two is one of the more useful things to understand about a market before you write an offer.

The honest summary on affordability

Broadly, and this does not change month to month: Boulder County is the most expensive tier in this guide. Fort Collins, Timnath and Windsor sit above Loveland and Greeley. Wellington, Severance, Eaton and the smaller Weld County towns are where new construction meets accessible pricing. Morgan County is a genuinely different price world. Foothills acreage is priced on land and views rather than square footage, which is why it does not compare cleanly to anything in town.

NEXT

What to do with this

Pick four towns from the table. Then send them to me and tell me what you are optimising for — a school, a commute, land, a budget, a feeling. I will tell you which of the four actually fits, and I will tell you if the answer is a fifth town you have not considered.

There is no obligation attached to that conversation and no drip campaign waiting on the other side of it. You are making a decision that is hard to reverse, months before you need an agent. Getting it right is worth a phone call either way.

Call or text	303-709-4262
Email	thelittleladyinc@gmail.com
Website	signaturepropertycollection.com
Brokerage	LPT Realty

Also on the website: an interactive map of all nine counties, drive times measured between real addresses, a walkability score for every town, video tours of the towns and of local restaurants and trails, a neighbourhood quiz that matches you against real towns, and a mortgage calculator.

Town data in this guide is generated from the same source that powers the signaturepropertycollection.com town pages, so it is maintained rather than written once. Nothing in here is a substitute for advice from a licensed inspector, lender, insurer, surveyor or attorney on a specific property. Equal Housing Opportunity.